Literature Review: Exchange, Society, and the Himalayan Salt Economy

1.1 Introduction

Salt has occupied a distinctive place in human history. Essential for survival yet unevenly distributed across landscapes, it has shaped patterns of mobility, exchange, political authority, and social organisation across diverse societies. Historical research on salt has examined trade, taxation, state monopoly, and imperialism, highlighting salt's economic significance for subsistence and government revenue (Lally, 2021; Taylor, 2023). These studies have enhanced our understanding of salt as a strategic good, especially in colonial administration and distant trade. Understanding the historical significance of salt therefore requires moving beyond its material value and examining the social institutions that shaped its circulation.

This question is particularly relevant to the Himalayan region. The Western Himalayas, encompassing one of the world's most biodiverse mountain systems, were bounded by pastoral plateaus, agricultural valleys, monastic centres, and frontier markets, and within this complex cultural landscape existed an extensive network of seasonal exchange. Salt from the saline lakes of Changthang flowed with pashm, wool, grain, tea, livestock, and other merchandise to connect peoples who inhabited different ecological zones (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). The Tibetan and Himalayan salt trade has attracted growing scholarship, and this chapter reviews these strands and their significance. Historians have generally focused on the structure of the salt trade, while anthropologists pay close attention to the details of everyday economic exchange and exchange systems, particularly salt extraction, pastoral mobility, and the spatial and social dimension of *netsang*—a system of fictive kinship that created exchange partnerships between different families across ecological zones. Rather than negotiating each transaction independently, trading partners entered into durable relationships characterised by mutual trust, hospitality, and reciprocal obligation. These partnerships reduced uncertainty within environments where long-distance travel was constrained by altitude, climate, and political frontiers. Within the Himalayan context, commodities circulated because social relationships already existed; exchange did not create these relationships as much as it continually reaffirmed them. This scholarship has shed light on the ancient trans-Himalayan trade. It is also valuable to consider how this trade has been transformed in the 19th and 20th centuries, through colonial rule, assimilation, and taxation.

Theoretical perspectives developed within anthropology, economic history and social theory provide an important framework for interpreting these historical processes. During the twentieth century scholars increasingly challenged the assumption that markets represented the universal basis of economic life. Marcel Mauss argued that early modes of exchange were based on reciprocity, not contract, while Karl Polanyi explained that non-market economies were embedded within other social institutions and were not isolated market systems. Following in this tradition, James C. Scott and E. P. Thompson explored the moral aspects of economic

behaviour, stressing the significance of custom, subsistence values, and conceptions of justice among common people's reactions to political and economic transformations (Thompson, 1971). More recently, scholars like Prasannan Parthasarathi pointed out that markets were constructed politically during colonial times, arguing that capitalism was a product of state intervention in history, and not a development from prior forms of economic organisation (Parthasarathi, 2011). These perspectives offer a conceptual framework for viewing exchange as an institution, not only an economic process.

To establish the conceptual basis for analysing the Himalayan salt economy, this chapter relies on these theories. Instead of providing a comprehensive analysis of each scholar's work separately, this chapter synthesises the key debates about exchange, embedded economies, moral economy, and colonial transformation of exchange systems, to place these debates within Himalayan historiography. It does not seek to force a theory upon historiography but identifies concepts that help explain the economy of salt production, exchange, and trade in the Himalayas. This emphasis on social relationships also raises the question of how connections between communities, institutions and places can be traced across historical sources. It informs the thesis's use of computational analysis to examine these connections, guided by the historical and anthropological perspectives reviewed here.

The chapter is organised into three substantive sections. The first focuses on the literature of gift-exchange systems as studied by Marcel Mauss and Karl Polanyi, and their rejection of the market-centred view of economic life. The second reviews debates on moral economy and colonial transformation, drawing upon the contributions of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi to examine how embedded systems of exchange were reshaped under colonial capitalism. The third section examines Himalayan historiography and studies the historiography and anthropology of salt, its ecological setting, and social formations within it.

1.2 Exchange, Reciprocity, and the Embedded Economy

How societies organised production and exchange before market capitalism is a central question in economic anthropology. Challenging classical economic assumptions about individual rationality and market exchange, Mauss and Polanyi approached this question by examining the obligations and institutions through which societies secured their material livelihoods.

Marcel Mauss' The Gift marked a decisive departure from earlier evolutionary theories that interpreted exchange as a progression from barter to markets. Rather than asking how commercial exchange developed, Mauss sought to understand why gifts, which appeared voluntary, generated enduring obligations between individuals and communities. His answer altered anthropological understandings of exchange. Gifts, he argued, were never simple transfers of property. They constituted "total social facts" in which economic activity remained inseparable from legal obligations, religious beliefs, political authority, moral expectations, and collective identity (Mauss, 2002, Introduction).

Mauss' formulation holds that gift exchange rests on three mutually reinforcing obligations: the obligation to give, the obligation to receive, and the obligation to reciprocate (Mauss, 2002, chs 1–2). These obligations transformed exchange from an act of individual generosity into a mechanism through which social relationships were continually reproduced. Refusing to give represented a failure of social responsibility; refusing to receive rejected the relationship offered by the giver; while accepting without reciprocating resulted in a loss of honour and social standing. Exchange was therefore governed not by contractual enforcement or monetary calculation but by reciprocal obligation and collective recognition. Wealth acquired value through circulation rather than accumulation, and prestige depended upon an individual's or community's capacity to participate in these reciprocal relationships.

Mauss illustrates these principles through the institution of the Potlatch among the Indigenous societies of the north-west coast of North America. During these elaborate ceremonial gatherings, chiefs distributed, consumed, and sometimes deliberately destroyed significant quantities of wealth before assembled communities. Judged according to modern economic rationality, such practices appear wasteful and economically irrational. Yet Mauss demonstrates that their significance lay precisely in their capacity to establish political authority, social prestige, and collective legitimacy. Wealth was accumulated to be given away, and generosity itself functioned as a source of power (Mauss, 2002, ch. 2).

Mauss' concept of *hau* or *mana* concerns the spiritual essence that lived in the object of exchange in Polynesia. For example, the gift was not considered a mere commodity detachable from its owner, but an item containing the essence of the giver, making the receiver accountable through continuing obligations (Mauss, 2002, ch. 1). Failure to reciprocate therefore represented more than economic indebtedness. It disrupted relationships that were simultaneously social, religious, and political.

Although Mauss convincingly established the social foundations of exchange, his analysis primarily concerned the circulation of gifts and the obligations generated between exchange partners. Karl Polanyi extended this insight by asking a broader question: if exchange was socially embedded, how were entire economies organised before the emergence of market society? His contribution shifted attention from individual acts of reciprocity to the institutional organisation of economic life, thereby providing a more comprehensive critique of market universalism.

Polanyi's distinction between formalist and substantivist economics is one of the most influential interventions in twentieth-century economic anthropology. Formalist economics defines economic activity as rational choice under conditions of scarcity and therefore assumes that market behaviour provides a universal model for analysing all societies. Polanyi rejected this assumption by arguing that such a definition reflects the historically specific conditions of capitalist economies rather than the organisation of economic life more generally. In its substantive sense, the economy refers simply to the institutional processes through which societies secure their material livelihoods (Polanyi, 1957, pp. 243–250).

Whereas Mauss focuses on the social obligations generated by gift exchange, Polanyi examines the institutional organisation of economies as a whole. Within this broader framework, Polanyi identified reciprocity, redistribution, and householding as the principal forms through which pre-market societies organised production and circulation. Reciprocity involved exchanges among socially affiliated groups under enduring obligations; redistribution entailed the collection of goods at politically or religiously centralised locations and their subsequent allocation throughout society; and householding centred on production for the collective needs of a relatively self-sufficient group. Markets certainly existed, but they remained subordinate to these wider institutional arrangements rather than regulating society itself (Polanyi, 2001, ch. 4).

These perspectives provide an important conceptual foundation for understanding historical exchange in frontier regions such as the Himalayas. A simple market perspective is not enough to analyse the movement of goods over long distances, since these goods were often transported through institutions based on kinship relations, customary obligations, ecological interdependence, and political power (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). Exchange therefore represented not merely the movement of goods but the reproduction of wider social relationships that enabled communities to survive within challenging environmental and political landscapes. Yet embedded economies were neither static nor immune to historical change. The expansion of colonial states, the emergence of capitalist markets, and the increasing regulation of labour and resources gradually transformed these earlier systems of reciprocity and redistribution. Understanding this transformation requires moving beyond embedded exchange towards questions of moral economy, customary rights, and colonial political economy—issues that form the focus of the following section.

1.3 Moral Economy, Colonial Transformation, and the Making of Markets

The expansion of capitalist markets, the consolidation of state authority, and the restructuring of labour fundamentally altered earlier systems of reciprocity, redistribution, and customary exchange. Historians and political economists therefore examine how these pre-market societies saw the rise of market capitalism rather than the way in which pre-market societies operated. Central to this scholarship is the recognition that markets did not simply replace earlier forms of exchange through economic efficiency or technological progress. Rather, they were historically produced through political intervention, institutional restructuring, and changing relations of power (Parthasarathi, 2011). The writings of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi have shaped this approach, although all of them study the problem from a different historical perspective.

James C. Scott’s concept of moral economy addresses subsistence and exchange. Writing primarily with reference to agrarian Southeast Asia, Scott challenged interpretations that viewed peasant behaviour as motivated principally by profit maximisation. Instead, he argued that subsistence constituted the central organising principle of peasant economic life. Communities

operating close to ecological and economic margins sought above all to minimise risk rather than maximise returns. This "safety-first" principle shaped decisions concerning production, labour, and exchange, favouring stability over commercial opportunity (Scott, 1976, ch. 1). Economic choices therefore reflected the constant need to preserve subsistence rather than accumulate wealth.

Scott further argues that pre-capitalist societies were sustained by moral expectations that regulated relationships between rulers and subjects. Reciprocal obligations extended beyond local communities to include landlords, village elites, and political authorities, who were expected to protect the subsistence of those under their authority during periods of crisis. Legitimacy therefore depended not simply upon legal sovereignty but upon adherence to widely recognised norms of reciprocity and social responsibility (Scott, 1976, chs 2 and 6). When these customary obligations were violated, whether through excessive taxation, inflexible revenue demands, or exploitative extraction, the resulting grievances were understood not merely as economic hardships but as breaches of an accepted moral order. Resistance consequently emerged not from abstract ideological commitments but from attempts to defend long-standing norms of subsistence and justice.

Although developed within a different historical setting, Scott's framework provides a valuable lens for interpreting frontier economies where livelihoods depended upon ecological uncertainty and seasonal exchange. Systems of reciprocity, customary obligation, and mutual assistance functioned not simply as cultural traditions but as practical mechanisms through which communities managed environmental risk. Thus, economic exchanges were linked with social security and contributed to the broader idea of Mauss and Polanyi that markets did not form the organising principles of pre-capitalist societies.

E. P. Thompson developed a related but distinct view and formulated the notion of moral economy through his research in eighteenth-century England. Like Mauss and Polanyi, Thompson dismissed purely economic explanations for the collective protests, stressing that such actions had more to do with traditional concepts of justice, rights, and legitimacy than just hunger. In his study of food riots, Thompson revealed that communities tended to preserve the traditional principles of distribution of vital resources, especially those challenged by market relations (Thompson, 1971, pp. 76–79). Markets, therefore, were experienced not simply as new economic institutions but as challenges to existing social relationships and collective understandings of justice.

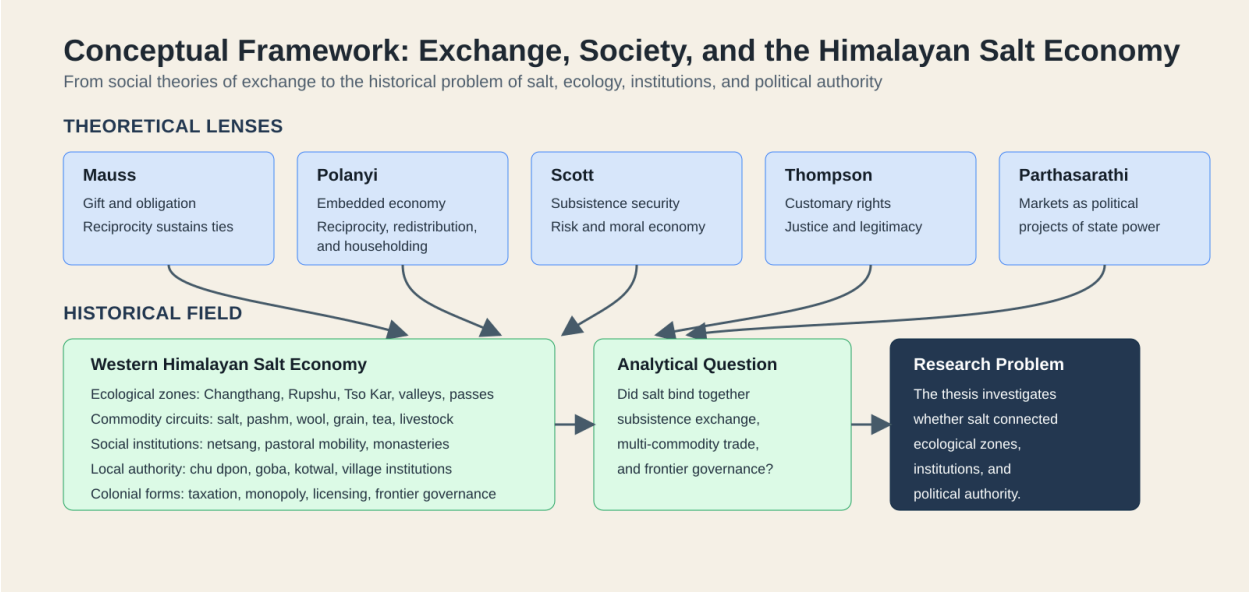
Thompson's broader contribution lies in his insistence that historical change cannot be understood solely through quantitative measures of economic growth or material welfare. Distinguishing between a "standard of life" and a "way of life," he argues that processes of capitalist transformation frequently undermined customary institutions, communal practices, and forms of local autonomy even where material conditions appeared to improve (Thompson, 1963, ch. 6). This distinction directs attention towards forms of dispossession that remain invisible within conventional economic analysis. The erosion of customary authority, communal regulation, and locally embedded knowledge represents a transformation of social life that cannot be captured through indicators such as prices, wages, or output alone.

Where Scott highlights the subsistence ethic that underpinned agrarian communities, Thompson draws attention to the customary rights and communal institutions disrupted by expanding market relations. The transition towards capitalist markets consequently involved not merely the introduction of new forms of exchange but the reorganisation of social relationships that had previously regulated production, distribution, and access to resources. These debates have been extended by Prasannan Parthasarathi, whose work on labour, industry, and colonial political economy challenges narratives that portray capitalism as the inevitable outcome of European economic superiority. Examining South Asia within a global comparative framework, Parthasarathi argues that markets are neither autonomous nor historically inevitable. Instead, they emerge through political decisions that reshape labour relations, production systems, and institutional structures. Colonial intervention therefore played a decisive role in reorganising existing economies, not by introducing markets into previously isolated societies, but by altering the conditions under which production and exchange were organised (Parthasarathi, 2001, pp. 1–10; 2011).

Parthasarathi's intervention shifts attention from exchange alone to the broader political economy of colonialism. The creation of new market relationships that favoured the interests of imperialism over the pre-existing systems of production was achieved through labour regimes, commerce, law, and the state (Parthasarathi, 2001).

Taken together, the works of Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi develop the institutional questions raised by Mauss and Polanyi by examining customary rights, subsistence expectations, labour arrangements, and political authority during periods of economic change. Although their historical settings differ, these scholars show how the organisation of production and exchange shaped relationships between communities, employers, traders, and rulers. Their work therefore provides a framework for examining both the obligations sustaining economic relationships and the interventions that altered them. It also directs attention to the uneven consequences of change: arrangements that created commercial opportunities for some groups could weaken the security or customary entitlements of others.

These questions are particularly relevant to the Himalayan salt economy, where production and circulation depended upon access to resources, seasonal mobility, organised labour, and relationships between trading communities and political authorities. The theoretical discussion directs attention to how reciprocal obligations, commercial calculation, customary rights, and regulation interacted within these arrangements. Their relationship, and the extent to which it changed, requires investigation in particular historical settings. The following section therefore turns to Himalayan scholarship, comparing how historians and anthropologists have interpreted the organisation of salt production and exchange, the authority exercised over them, and their transformation across different regions and periods.



1.4 Salt, economy, and political authority in the Himalayas

Salt connected Himalayan livelihoods with wider systems of exchange and political authority. Its circulation linked commodities, communities, and institutions through arrangements governing production, transport, and access. This review examines how historical and anthropological scholarship interprets those connections, focusing on regional production, reciprocal exchange, Rupshu's labour organisation, ritual practice, and contested rights. The relationship between customary institutions and state regulation is treated as a historical question rather than a complete transition from one system to another. The principal focus remains Ladakh and Rupshu–Tso Kar, with Tibetan, Nepalese, Kumaoni, and Kinnauri studies supplying comparisons.

Ecological differences help explain why these exchanges developed. Pastoral plateaus supplied salt, wool, pashm, and livestock, while agricultural valleys provided grain and other provisions. Lazcano distinguishes the Changthang lake sources, the Tsaidam salt region of Amdo, and Tsakalho's terraced saltpans on the upper Mekong (2022, p. 71). These were different production settings, rather than interchangeable parts of one Himalayan economy. Rizvi describes an annual October exchange at Chemrey–Sakti, where Chang-pa brought salt from the plateau lakes on the backs of sheep, while villagers from across Ladakh brought grain from their fields to barter for it. Shamma traders acquired salt in bulk and carried it to the Suru valley and Baltistan, exchanging it for grain or dried apricots; the apricots could subsequently be sold for cash in Leh or Srinagar. These journeys connected pastoral salt production, agricultural provisioning, and further commercial exchanges (Rizvi, 1996, p. 100). Salt's importance therefore lay partly in the relationships through which communities secured goods unavailable locally, although ecological complementarity alone cannot explain who controlled trade or benefited from it.

Mobility depended on household labour, animals, and seasonal conditions. Rizvi notes that some Shamma traders remained away from their villages for up to ten months of the year. These prolonged journeys were supported by joint-family arrangements: usually one adult man undertook the trading, while other household members—including his brothers, wife, and unmarried sisters—continued the agricultural work. Long-distance commerce could therefore proceed while cultivation continued at home (Rizvi, 1996, p. 100). Ahmed describes smaller herd owners accompanying larger ones to Tibetan salt lakes in return for work (1999, p. 33), showing how differences in transport resources shaped participation. At Tso Kar, extraction usually occurred in September or October, but rainfall and drying conditions could shift the date (p. 41, note 21). Ecological rhythms therefore constrained journeys without producing a fixed calendar for the entire region. The connection between pastoralism and commerce involved practical arrangements and unequal opportunities as well as environmental adaptation.

Rizvi also complicates a strict separation between subsistence and commercial activity. She distinguishes salt–grain–wool exchange from the higher-value pashm trade but shows how Shamma traders participated in both. They sold pashm for cash, bought salt, and made gains through further exchanges (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 99–100). Barter could therefore involve calculation and profit. Salt's circulation connected pastoral production, agricultural provisioning, and commercial exchange, providing a starting point for reconstructing wider Himalayan commodity networks. This thesis places salt at the centre of that reconstruction, examining how, and to what extent, its routes and exchange relationships formed a backbone linking different commodities, communities, and institutions.

The social organisation of exchange likewise requires attention to commerce alongside obligation. Lecoq describes Nepalese caravan traders staying with established ceremonial partners who provided food, accommodation, and a pen for their animals. The traders reciprocated with highland products such as wool, butter, and cheese, and the partners agreed the terms of barter (2022, p. 48). These relationships supplied practical support for journeys through which traders obtained grain. Similarly, Rizvi explains that joint-family arrangements enabled Shamma traders to undertake profitable trading journeys while other household members continued cultivation (1996, pp. 99–100). In these cases, trading partnerships and household cooperation helped sustain food supplies and agricultural work while enabling commercial exchange.

Ahmed's Rupshu study moves the analysis from circulation to the organisation of salt collection. Each household was required to send a man to the salt march or arrange for a relative to collect its share. The men worked in teams known as chu lag. Although team members could be related, they did not necessarily belong to the same pha spun, or patri-fraternal group (1999, pp. 41–42). Within each team, some men broke the salt crust, others filled tins, and others carried the salt to the bank. Despite sharing these tasks, each man maintained a separate pile, marked it for identification, and filled his own saddle-bags (pp. 42–43). Cooperation therefore organised the work of extraction, while the collected salt remained in separately identifiable shares that participants took home.

The details of allocation make these distinctions concrete. Ahmed describes four extraction groups headed by a chu dpon, with the kotwal dividing the lake and dice determining the order of selection. A requirement to fill twenty-five saddle-bags followed complaints about unequal extraction by larger herd owners (1999, p. 42). Such rules reveal efforts to manage competing interests within cooperative work. After collection, salt had several destinations: household consumption, religious contributions, barter, and sale (p. 45). Following these transfers avoids treating every movement as an equivalent exchange and shows how the same commodity connected livelihoods, obligations, and access claims.

The anthropology of salt extends to ritual knowledge and gender. Lazcano describes male Tibetan salt expeditions whose participants assumed family-modelled roles involving offerings, cooking, apprenticeship, and animal care. These were caravan roles, rather than an ordinary Rupshu household. Restricted salt vocabulary and rules concerning local deities connected work with ritual discipline (Lazcano, 2022, pp. 71–72). His account of women's work at Tsakalho contrasts with the predominantly male lake-salt collection (pp. 83–84). Meanwhile, Ahmed associates Rupshu's annual trek with male identity and attachment to Tso Kar (1999, p. 47). These differences show how production and mobility reproduced particular social identities rather than one uniform Himalayan division of labour.

Resource rights also generated conflict. Ahmed examines rival Rupshu and Kharnak claims involving monasteries, local leaders, administrative authorities, and courts (1999, pp. 43–45). The disputes concerned pasture and land as well as salt. Monasteries could receive contributions or support competing claims, so religious institutions cannot collectively be treated as neutral centres of redistribution. Customary authority operated through negotiation, exclusion, and enforcement. Customary, religious, and administrative powers interacted within the same disputes.

Ahmed also complicates a continuous history of Tso Kar extraction. Earlier written descriptions and retrospective accounts do not establish an agreed chronology before the 1960s (1999, pp. 38–40). Legends concerning the lake and exchanges with people of a hidden valley illuminate cultural memory, but cannot independently date commercial activity. Her account of preferences for local salt in butter-tea further explains persistence despite declining returns (pp. 46–47). Salt's value could include taste, identity, and attachment as well as price. The literature therefore requires distinguishing accounts of meaning from evidence of when, where, and how much salt was produced or traded.

The political interpretation becomes more specific through Alam's study of Mandi. He links intervention in salt administration, payment, and labour arrangements with popular grievances and royal authority, interpreting the reforms as a successful conversion to cash (Alam, 2007, pp. 175–178). Mandi offers a concrete setting for examining how economic arrangements shaped political legitimacy. It should not stand for all Himalayan salt production: mine administration differed from lake extraction, and princely authority differed from village institutions. The comparison asks what particular interventions changed, rather than assuming a complete regional replacement of reciprocity by bureaucracy.

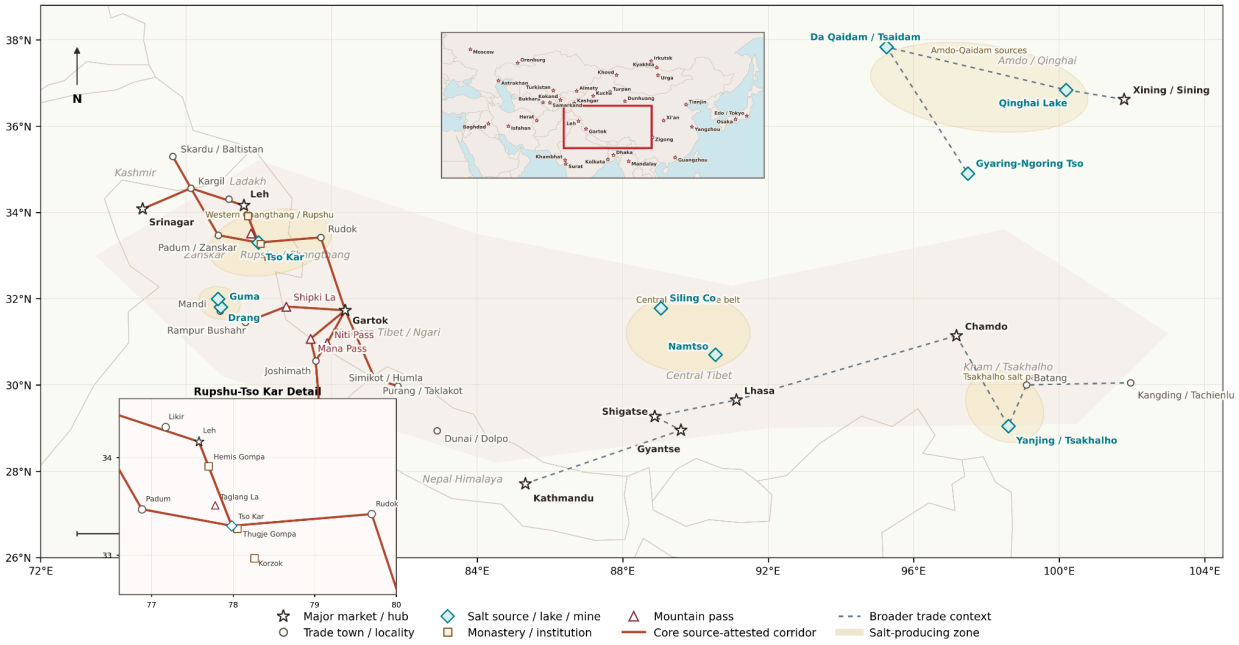
Bergmann's Kumaon study further qualifies that replacement narrative. His analysis of negotiations over land revenue and trade duties shows British authorities accommodating overlapping claims while seeking to preserve commercial access (2016, pp. 96–98). Political intervention could protect opportunities as well as restrict movement. Alam's comparison of the Lavi fair and Shimla market similarly treats commodity journeys as constitutive of commercial space and borders (2021, pp. 173–174). These works already interpret circulation politically. The thesis can develop their arguments through salt-focused comparison, but should not describe existing scholarship as merely descriptive or claim to discover Himalayan interconnectedness.

Wider salt histories provide a selective comparison. Lally's colonial Burma study emphasises negotiated sovereignty and uneven fiscal administration, while Taylor examines producer and merchant interests within Indian salt supply and regulation (Lally, 2021; Taylor, 2023). Together they distinguish political authority from uniform enforcement and consumers' interests from those of producers and traders. Their relevance lies in the questions they raise for Himalayan evidence, not in demonstrating identical arrangements there. Salt politics involved the practical organisation of production, circulation, and revenue, rather than taxation alone.

Historical change also followed different regional chronologies. Dollfus's Kharnak account and Singh and colleagues' Rupshu study associate major transformations with post-1962 border restrictions, military presence, provisioning, and changing livelihoods (Dollfus, 2012, pp. 66–68; Singh et al., 2013, PDF pp. 6, 9–10). These developments must be distinguished from colonial fiscal intervention. Beszterda's Kinnaur study describes a later commodity mix shaped by inexpensive plains salt and shows currency-denominated calculation alongside settlement in goods (2017, pp. 39, 45). Reopening a route therefore does not necessarily restore its earlier economic organisation. Participants, commodities, transport, and regulatory conditions may all have changed.

Across this literature, ecological interdependence, commercial calculation, social obligation, and political authority frequently coexist. The important contrasts concern production methods, access rights, gendered labour, and the mechanisms and timing of change. These findings connect circulation and power through historically specific arrangements. They also prevent social embeddedness from becoming a claim that exchange was harmonious, unchanging, or without unequal benefits. Their differences also require distinguishing consumers' needs from the privileges and obligations of those extracting and transporting salt.

The present thesis accordingly investigates whether salt linked selected commodities, communities, places, and authorities within a defined Western Himalayan corpus. The relationship between circulation and governance is approached as a research question to be assessed through specific historical evidence. Comparing source-attributed relationships can develop the regional scholarship while preserving differences between periods and jurisdictions. Salt's connective importance remains to be tested: repeated mentions and network centrality cannot alone establish economic dependence. The following chapter examines the documentary evidence and its limits before the methodology and results chapters assess these relationships.



1.5 Conclusion

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates that exchange cannot be understood as a purely economic phenomenon governed solely by market forces. Across anthropology, economic history, and political economy, scholars have consistently challenged the assumption that markets constitute the natural or universal basis of economic organisation (Polanyi, 1944/2001). Instead, the works of Marcel Mauss, Karl Polanyi, James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi collectively illustrate that economic life has historically been embedded within wider systems of reciprocity, customary rights, political authority, ecological constraints, and moral obligations. Although these scholars differ in their historical contexts and analytical emphasis, they converge in rejecting market universalism and instead emphasise the social and political institutions through which exchange was organised. Together, they provide an important conceptual framework for examining societies where economic activity cannot be separated from the broader structures of social life.

These theoretical frameworks are particularly useful for comprehending the history of the Himalayan salt economy. Beyond its role as a tradable item, salt played an important part in interrelated systems of pastoral migration, ecological adaption, religious rituals, and local governance. Historical and anthropological research has shown that its distribution was based on reciprocity, caravan arrangements, redistribution by monasteries, customary regulations, and ecological complementarity. Thus, trade in the Western Himalayas operated through social systems that linked people across ecological zones in long-term relationships. Salt emerged not

simply as an object of commerce but as a medium through which communities negotiated survival, authority, and interdependence within a geographically fragmented frontier (Ahmed, 1999, pp. 43–45).

At the same time, the reviewed literature indicates that these embedded systems of exchange were neither static nor isolated from wider historical processes. Colonial rule transformed these institutions through taxation, monopolies, licensing, frontier administration, and increasing bureaucratisation. Such transformations did not merely alter patterns of trade; they reshaped the political and social relationships through which exchange had previously been organised. Consequently, the Himalayan salt economy must be understood not only in terms of commodity circulation but also as part of a broader history of state formation, frontier governance, and colonial political economy.

The principal gap, therefore, concerns the reconstruction of connections across commodities, routes, institutions, and political authorities. This study is situated within this historiographical context. Instead of supplanting this historical and anthropological research, this thesis aims to supplement these works by bringing together archival evidence on the Western Himalayan salt trade. In doing so, it uses an interdisciplinary methodology based on historical analysis of archival evidence to explore the interconnections between commodities, routes, institutions and political agents. The objective is not simply to reconstruct individual episodes of trade but to understand the wider networks through which salt shaped frontier economies and political authority during the colonial period. Computational analysis supports this task by helping to trace connections across dispersed archival accounts (Painter et al., 2019). The social and historical perspectives reviewed in this chapter guide the interpretation of the resulting patterns of exchange.

The following chapter therefore moves from theoretical and historiographical discussions to the historical sources themselves. It examines the principal archival materials including gazetteers, colonial administrative reports, treaties, travel accounts, and Foreign Department records that document the circulation of salt across the Western Himalayas. The archives serve as the empirical base for building historical networks of connections established via the salt trade.

References

Ahmed, M. (1999). The salt trade: Rupshu's annual trek to Tso Kar. In M. van Beek, K. B. Bertelsen, & P. Pedersen (Eds.), *Ladakh: Culture, history, and development between Himalaya and Karakoram* (pp. 32–48). Aarhus University Press. https://ladakhstudies.org/ladakh-culture-history-and-development-between-himalaya-and-karakoram/

Alam, A. (2007). *Becoming India: Western Himalayas under British rule*. Foundation Books. https://doi.org/10.1017/UPO9788175968387

Alam, A. (2021). Commodity journeys and market circuits: Making borders 'natural' in colonial Western Himalayas. In F. Ibrahim and T. Kothiyal (Eds.), *South Asian borderlands: Mobility, history, affect* (pp. 172–195). Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781108951500.008

Bergmann, C. (2016). Confluent territories and overlapping sovereignties: Britain's nineteenth-century Indian empire in the Kumaon Himalaya. *Journal of Historical Geography, 51*, 88–98. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhg.2015.06.015

Beszterda, R. (2017). Current analyses on Shipki-la trade, Kinnaur 2017. *Ethnologia Polona, 37*, 31–52.https://journals.iaepan.pl/ethp/article/view/65

Dollfus, P. (2013). Transformation processes in nomadic pastoralism in Ladakh. *Himalaya, 32*(1), 61–72. https://digitalcommons.macalester.edu/himalaya/vol32/iss1/15/

Lally, J. (2021). Salt and sovereignty in colonial Burma. *The Historical Journal, 64*(3), 650–673. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0018246X20000370

Lazcano, S. (2022). The salt trips in Tibet and the Himalayas: Extraction and trade in pre-modern times. *Revue d'Études Tibétaines, 65*, 70–103. https://d1i1jdw69xsqx0.cloudfront.net/digitalhimalaya/collections/journals/ret/pdf/ret_65.pdf

Lecoq, P. (2022). Salt routes and barter caravans in the Himalayan regions of Nepal and Tibet from an ethnographical perspective. In P. B. Clarkson & C. M. Santoro (Eds.), *Caravans in socio-cultural perspective: Past and present* (pp. 39–53). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003179276-4

Mauss, M. (2001). *The gift: The form and reason for exchange in archaic societies* (W. D. Halls, Trans.; 2nd ed.). Routledge. (Original work published 1925). https://www.routledge.com/The-Gift/Mauss/p/book/9780415267496

Painter, D. T., Daniels, B. C., & Jost, J. (2019). Network analysis for the digital humanities: Principles, problems, extensions. *Isis, 110*(3), 538–554. https://doi.org/10.1086/705532

Parthasarathi, P. (2001). *The transition to a colonial economy: Weavers, merchants and kings in South India, 1720–1800*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511497414

Parthasarathi, P. (2011). *Why Europe grew rich and Asia did not: Global economic divergence, 1600–1850*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511993398

Polanyi, K. (1957). The economy as instituted process. In K. Polanyi, C. M. Arensberg, & H. W. Pearson (Eds.), *Trade and market in the early empires: Economies in history and theory* (pp. 243–270). Free Press. https://archive.org/details/in.gov.ignca.36501

Polanyi, K. (with Stiglitz, J. E., & Block, F.). (2001). *The great transformation: The political and economic origins of our time*. Beacon Press. https://www.beacon.org/The-Great-Transformation-P46.aspx (Original work published 1944)

Rizvi, J. (1995). Merchants and mountains: The trade routes of Northwest India. *Himalayan Journal, 51*. https://www.himalayanclub.org/hj/51/13/merchants-and-mountains/

Rizvi, J. (1996). *Ladakh: Crossroads of High Asia* (2nd ed.). Oxford University Press. https://books.google.com/books?id=xoluAAAAMAAJ

Scott, J. C. (1976). *The moral economy of the peasant: Rebellion and subsistence in Southeast Asia*. Yale University Press. https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1bh4cdk

Singh, N. J., Bhatnagar, Y. V., Lecomte, N., Fox, J. L., & Yoccoz, N. G. (2013). No longer tracking greenery in high altitudes: Pastoral practices of Rupshu nomads and their implications for biodiversity conservation. *Pastoralism, 3*, Article 16. https://doi.org/10.1186/2041-7136-3-16

Taylor, M. (2023). The ungrudging Indian: The political economy of salt in India, c. 1878–1947. *South Asia: Journal of South Asian Studies, 46*(4), 791–805. https://doi.org/10.1080/00856401.2023.2245235

Thompson, E. P. (1963). *The making of the English working class*. Victor Gollancz. https://archive.org/details/makingofenglishw0000thom

Thompson, E. P. (1971). The moral economy of the English crowd in the eighteenth century. *Past & Present, 50*(1), 76–136. https://doi.org/10.1093/past/50.1.76